Limitations and potential

Some ecology research projects are beyond the reach of untrained amateurs because they require too high a degree of skill, or technology that is too complex or expensive. People unfamiliar with scientific methods may also introduce bias into recordings, such as by the omission of a species that cannot be identified.

Most simple citizen science tasks, though, require no training, and some other, more complex, procedures can be tackled after basic tuition. People are often attracted to citizen science precisely because they gain new skills in the process. Increasing pressure on Earth's natural environments and resources creates an ever greater need for data that records presence, absence, and change in species, their habitats, and the wider ecosystems. Projects such as Zooniverse, the world's largest citizen science platform with more than 2.8 million registered volunteers, help to fill this need, accumulating data worldwide. Such projects will be an invaluable resource for conservation organizations, research institutions, nongovernment agencies, and governments for years to come.